Local Competition in Mexican Politics since 1979: A Comprehensive Dataset of Municipal Elections

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November 9, 2026
Forthcoming in *Mexican Studies/Estudios Mexicanos*

Abstract

I introduce a publicly available dataset of vote returns for Mexican municipal elections between 1979 and 2025. The dataset includes more than 35,000 races and provides municipality-level aggregates for votes won by each party, the number of registered voters, the number of candidates competing, the winner's name, the election date and whether it was held concurrently with other races, and identification codes for merging socio-demographic data. I present the data sources, explain the standardization of the time-series cross-sectional structure, and provide descriptive statistics. Patterns in the data are consistent with existing knowledge of Mexican elections and demonstrate several promising applications of the dataset.

Presento una base de datos de acceso público sobre los resultados electorales de las elecciones municipales en México entre 1979 y 2025. La base comprende más de 35,000 contiendas electorales e incluye información agregada a nivel municipal sobre la votación obtenida por cada partido, la lista nominal, el número de candidaturas participantes, el nombre de la persona ganadora, la fecha de la elección y si ésta se celebró de manera concurrente con otros comicios, así como claves de identificación que permiten vincular los datos con información sociodemográfica. Describo las fuentes de información, explico los procedimientos utilizados para estandarizar la estructura longitudinal y transversal de la base de datos y presento estadísticas descriptivas. Los patrones observados son consistentes con el conocimiento existente sobre las elecciones en México y muestran diversas aplicaciones potenciales de esta base de datos.

*The author is grateful for financial support for research from the Asociación Mexicana de Cultura A.C. and for research assistance by Gabino Martínez Díaz, Isaac Palatto Sánchez, Rodrigo Santibáñez Razo, and Carlos Alexis Sarabia Melgarejo. All remaining errors are my own.

To Juan Molinar Horcasitas (1955–2015)
pioneer of Mexican electoral studies
in memoriam

The advent of partisan competition in Mexican politics coincided with the release of a wealth of public data across multiple areas of government. This development fueled a boom in the study of politics, public policy, and administrative processes in fields as diverse as the data itself, including poverty alleviation, decentralized spending, public health, education, infrastructure, special interest groups, organized crime, and indigenous protest movements.[1] These policy analyses are typically conducted using small units of observation, such as firms, schools, census tracts, or even individuals, yet the processes under study invariably intersect with municipal governments, and multivariate models commonly include controls at this level. Municipal election vote returns constitute a key input for empirical analysis.

This research note introduces a dataset of vote returns for Mexican municipal government elections over recent decades. Although vote returns are public information and can generally be found online with relative ease, the primary sources are dispersed across state-level websites, lack standardized reporting formats, contain many missing or incomplete years, and in some cases have been—or are at risk of being—removed because of insufficient funding. These limitations underscore the importance of maintaining a secondary source. The dataset is distributed through a publicly available repository that consolidates municipal election results nationwide into a single comprehensive source. The data cover all municipalities that held local government elections between 1979 and 2025.

Repositories and websites providing historical vote returns for national legislative and executive elections at different levels of aggregation are numerous in both consolidated and consolidating democracies, including Mexico (INE 2026).[2] By contrast, efforts to compile and distribute historical vote returns for *subnational* offices remain uncommon. This dataset joins a small number of similar initiatives in other countries of which I am aware, including a comprehensive database of U.S. local elections for 1989–2021 developed by Benedictis-Kessner (de), an archive of local election results in Great Britain compiled by Teale (2026), and the dataset on the partisan composition of Swiss cantonal governments from 1848 to 2017 assembled by Walter and Emmenegger (2018).

The note proceeds as follows. Section 1 describes municipal government authority and the relevant electoral institutions. Section 2 examines municipal party systems and introduces the principal parties competing in these elections. Section 3 briefly discusses electoral fraud in Mex-

[1] See Avitabile and De Hoyos (2018); Behrman et al. (2025); Cantú (2019*b*); De la O (2013); Dell (2015); Díaz Cayeros, Estévez and Magaloni (2016); Dube, García Ponce and Thom (2016); Frenk (2006); Garfias, López Videla and Sandholtz (2021); Hernández Trillo and Jarillo Rabling (2008); King et al. (2007); Palmer-Rubin (2019); Timmons and Broid (2013); Trejo (2009).

[2] For instance, see MIT (2017) and ICPSR (2025) for U.S. presidential and Congressional elections since 1824; Cracknell, Uberoi and Burton (2023) for United Kingdom general elections since 1983; Intérieur (2026) and Gougou (2025) for French presidential and National Assembly elections since 1958. Two remarkable endeavors systematizing and distributing a cross-national time-series of district-level election returns for the national assembly are Cox and Lijphart (2009) and Kollman et al. (2024).

ico. Section 4 details the data coverage and the organization of the distributed files. Section 5 provides an overview of pre-electoral coalitions in the units of observation, which pose challenges for some lines of research. Section 6 presents descriptive analyses of key variables in the dataset, comparing municipal patterns to findings from previous scholarship on federal, state, and subnational elections. Sections 7 and 8 describe additional datasets distributed alongside the main database, containing systematic information on elected municipal executives and electoral calendars, respectively, since 1989. Section 9 concludes.

1 Municipal governments

As of May 2025, Mexico's thirty-one states were divided into 2,460 municipalities, in addition to 17 municipality-equivalent jurisdictions in Mexico City, the nation's capital. *Municipios* elect the lowest tier of government in Mexico's federal system. Because scholarly knowledge of subnational government and policy remains limited, I provide a brief institutional overview.

1.1 Policy making and fiscal authority

Municipal governments have constitutional authority over community policing, zoning and construction permits, drinking water supply, sewerage and waste disposal, street lighting, road paving, and park management, and they regulate public markets, slaughterhouses, and cemeteries. However, municipalities possess limited constitutional fiscal authority, raising only property taxes and user fees for public services. Historically, few municipalities invested in the administrative capacity necessary for effective revenue collection (Garfias 2018). Most municipalities—especially those in rural areas—derive most of their financial resources from federal revenue-sharing arrangements and earmarked federal transfers for public investment (Díaz Cayeros 2006; Figueroa Mansur 2024).

Despite the limited scope of municipal authority, elected local officials appoint administrative staff and contract services and personnel, making municipal governments important sources of patronage within any spoils system. Local political organizations, and the resources they mobilize in pursuit of municipal office, are therefore central to maintaining state- and national-level parties (Ames 1970; Coppedge 1993; Key 1964; Rosas and Lucardi 2020). For this reason, municipal politics occupies an important place in the study of politics and public policy.

With some exceptions, state capacity in Mexico is notoriously limited, particularly at the municipal level. In 2023, the median municipal government employed 13 bureaucrats per 1,000 registered voters, while the lower quartile employed 9 or fewer. By contrast, municipalities in the top decile employed 32 or more bureaucrats per 1,000 registered voters—roughly two and a half times

the median level.[3]

1.2 Government structure

Municipal authority is vested in a popularly elected body known as the *Ayuntamiento* (literally 'yoked together'). The Ayuntamiento consists of the municipal council, or *cabildo*, and a mayor—called *presidente municipal* in some states, *primer regidor* in others—and decisions are made by majority rule. The mayor serves as the chief executive officer, presides over council sessions with voice and a tie-breaking vote, and exercises varying appointment powers depending on the state (Ramírez Millán 2000; Robles Martínez 2009). The size of the cabildo is proportional to population. Councilors, known as *regidores* or *concejales*, hold ranked positions of precedence and propose and vote municipal policy through ordinances and regulations. The council also includes one or more *síndicos*, officials responsible for treasury oversight and legal representation of the municipality. Síndicos may be either elected or appointed; appointed síndicos may speak in council sessions but do not have voting rights. Municipal governments possess no judicial authority, which instead resides with the states.

Although Mexico City is included in the dataset, I exclude it from the discussion below because of its special institutional status. Prior to 1997, the mayor of the Federal District was appointed by the president, and in turn appointed delegates to govern the city's sixteen administrative jurisdictions, known as *delegaciones*. Reforms enacted in 1997 converted all these positions into elected offices. The Federal District did not, however, acquire statehood, nor did the executives of the delegaciones obtain independent fiscal authority, as taxation remained under the control of the city executive. Further reforms in 2018 introduced councils for the city's quasi-municipal jurisdictions—renamed *alcaldías*—and formally changed the name of the Federal District to Mexico City (Rabell García 2017).

1.3 Electoral institutions

Mayors are elected by plurality rule. In every municipality, regidores are elected through a mixed system in which one group is chosen by plurality and another through proportional representation (PR). The ratio of plurality to PR regidores varies considerably across states. As of 2010, the average Ayuntamiento had a ratio of approximately $2:1$. In the state of Guanajuato, which had the lowest plurality share, the ratio was $1:4$, whereas in Tabasco, which had the highest plurality share, the ratio was the inverse, $4:1$ (Gil Ramírez 2010:14). This institutional variation matters because higher numbers of PR regidores could leave the president in the council minority.

[3] Descriptive statistics computed with data from the 2023 Municipal Government Census (INEGI 2023), excluding Mexico City and unelected municipalities.

When plurality and PR seats are evenly balanced, however, the mayor necessarily enjoys majority status in the council because municipal officers are elected in fused tickets. Voters cast a single vote for a party list that includes the municipal president at the top of the ticket, followed by ranked regidores and, where applicable, síndicos. The vote is 'fused' in the sense that it simultaneously determines the allocation of multiple offices (see Cox 1997:42): the municipal presidency, all plurality regidor seats, and elected síndico positions are awarded to the list receiving the most votes. The remaining regidor seats are then distributed proportionally across closed party lists. As a result, split-ticket voting is not technically possible.

1.4 Exceptional electoral institutions

Three notable exceptions exist in the states of Chihuahua, Nayarit, and Tlaxcala, which adopted alternative electoral arrangements between 1998 and 2008. In these states, municipal voters cast two votes rather than one, thereby making split-ticket voting possible.

In Chihuahua since 1998, one vote elects the síndico by plurality, while the second elects the remaining municipal officers under the system described above, with a plurality-to-PR ratio of $8:5$.

In Nayarit since 2008, one vote elects a fused president and síndico ticket through municipality-wide plurality elections. The second vote elects plurality regidores in single-member districts known as *demarcaciones*, into which municipalities are subdivided for this purpose. The second votes are subsequently pooled in a secondary district (the municipio as a whole) to allocate PR regidor seats across closed party lists. Although the plurality-to-PR ratio in Nayarit is $7:3$, mayors may nonetheless end up in the council minority if their party fails to secure a sufficient number of district victories (Lucardi and Magar 2019).

And Tlaxcala's *presidencias de comunidad*—decentralized municipal territorial administrative units—are elected agencies and, since 2008, ex officio members of municipal councils with voice. Although they remain subordinate to the municipal government, their institutional significance increased substantially in 2018, when the state's Municipal Law granted each community president a vote in the council—turning them into quasi-regidores analogous to Nayarit's. This reform fundamentally upended municipal government coalition-building. Whereas Tlaxcalteca municipalities have five to seven regidores, depending on population size, the average municipality has 6.5 community presidencies,[4] letting them collectively match or exceed the voting strength of the rest of council members. Three municipalities—including Tlaxco, which has 37 community presidencies—successfully challenged the reform before the Supreme Court, which in 2020

[4]Fifteen of Tlaxcala's municipalities have no such agencies, twenty have between 1 and 6 community presidencies, twenty have between 7 and 13, and five have between 15 and 39. Some community presidents are appointed by usos y costumbres.

invalidated the voting rights of community presidents in their respective councils only.

1.5 Term limits

Elected municipal officers serve three-year terms.[5] Until the expiration of terms ending in 2017, all municipal offices were subject to single-term limits. In a surprising departure from longstanding practice, reformers abolished Mexico's eighty-year constitutional prohibition on consecutive reelection during the mid-2010s. A decade later, however, counter-reformers reinstated the ban, so that all officials elected in 2030 and thereafter will once again be limited to a single term. In the interim period, states were permitted to allow municipal officials to serve up to two consecutive terms. All states except Hidalgo and Veracruz did so, with the reform taking effect in twenty-three states during the 2018 elections. In the remaining seven reforming states, incumbents gradually became eligible to seek reelection in subsequent electoral cycles.

Although limited in scope and illustrative of what Cox and McCubbins (2001) describe as state irresoluteness, this brief experiment with reelection is nonetheless likely to have left a systematic imprint on municipal politics. Six consecutive years in office fall short of a long political horizon, but doubling the tenure of Ayuntamientos should encourage more forward-looking and enterprising policy. More fundamentally, the prospect of reelection is expected to incentivize ambitious mayors and regidores to invest substantially in maintaining and mobilizing their electoral alliances (Cain, Ferejohn and Fiorina 1987; Motolinia 2021). In turn, these incentives should foster greater responsiveness in municipal distributive politics (Cox and McCubbins 1986; Jacobson and Kernell 1983). The adoption of reelection and its subsequent repeal therefore provide a unique laboratory for studying institutional change at the center of a broad tradition of political theory extending from *The Federalist Papers* to contemporary scholarship (Madison, Hamilton and Jay 1961; Mayhew 1974; Miller and Hammond 1989; Schlesinger 1966). Section 7 reports broad reelection patterns by party.

1.6 Usos y costumbres

A final note before proceeding concerns another set of observations that is excluded from the dataset. Of Oaxaca's 570 municipalities, only 152 elect their Ayuntamientos through popular vote. The remainder, most of which have predominantly indigenous populations, have opted out of the conventional electoral process since 1995 and instead appoint local authorities through customary community assemblies and councils under the system known as *usos y costumbres* (see Eisenstadt

[5] Ayuntamientos elected in Coahuila between 2005 and 2013 (inclusive), in Hidalgo since 2016, and in Veracruz since 2013 have served four-year terms. Additional deviations from the standard three-year term also occurred when states modified their electoral calendars, a relatively common development during this period (see section 8).

and Ríos 2014; Elizarrarás 2002; Magaloni, Gosztonyi and Thompson 2021). Seven municipalities in three other states acquired the same status over the past decade. For obvious reasons, these 425 usos y costumbres municipalities are excluded from the dataset.[6]

2 The parties

The main dataset is party-centric in the sense that it seeks to report systematically the votes won by each party in every race, although this objective may not always be achievable when pre-electoral coalitions are present (see section 5). A second, person-centric dataset containing information on elected mayors—that is, winning municipal presidential candidates—is also distributed, although for a shorter time span (see section 7).

Political parties operate within a highly regulated electoral environment. Mexican election law establishes formidable barriers to entry and grants federal and state electoral authorities broad powers over party organization, candidate selection, and campaigns (Estévez 2007; Magar 2015). Some regulations date back decades. One example is party registration, a draconian institution adopted by the PRI at the height of its hegemonic rule to discourage defections. Under this system, any party failing to reach the 3 percent vote threshold not only loses eligibility for proportional representation seats—as in Germany—but also ceases to exist legally. Most of the current regulatory framework, however, emerged during the 1990s, when a system based primarily on private, largely undisclosed, party and campaign finance was rapidly replaced by one centered on generous public subsidies (Poiré 2005). These subsidies, allocated in proportion to the party's vote share in the previous election, are distributed annually to party leaders, who retain broad discretion over their use. Given these powerful incentives and penalties, strong discipline toward party leadership is unsurprising (Weldon 1997).

2.1 Major parties

In broad chronological terms, Mexico's party system evolved from single-party hegemony to a competitive and volatile three-party system at the turn of the twenty-first century. Two decades of divided government followed, culminating in the rise of a new dominant party that left the former trio of major parties in a weakened electoral position. A brief overview of the principal parties during this period follows.

Partido Revolucionario Institucional: For most of eight decades, the **PRI** functioned as Mexico's hegemonic party and at times came close to outright single-party rule (Molinar Hor-

[6] A note 'To uyc in [*year*]' indicates the electoral cycle immediately anteceding a municipality's exit from both the

casitas 1991). The party was successfully challenged in the mid-1990s by the rise of the PAN and the PRD. Traditionally pragmatic and nationalist in orientation, the PRI came under the control of a technocratic neoliberal faction during the 1980s (Dresser 1991). The sitting president served as the party's undisputed national leader, while governors exercised leadership at the state level (Langston 2010). Long unmatched in electoral organization, the PRI's vote-getting machinery gradually weakened as rapid social change combined with the deeply unpopular austerity policies of the 1980s. As discussed below, however, this erosion proceeded much more slowly at the local level.

Partido Acción Nacional: The **PAN** was the principal—and at times the only credible—opposition to PRI hegemony. Its core support has traditionally come from urban middle classes and socially conservative constituencies, particularly in central Mexico (Loaeza 2010). During the 1990s, the PAN exchanged its pivotal votes in Congress for economic reforms in return for solid guarantees of free and fair elections (Cornelius 1996), as well as larger state transfers through revenue-sharing arrangements (Díaz Cayeros 2006; Shirk 2005). The center-right party won the presidency in 2000 and again in 2006, the latter by a paper-thin margin. Although the PAN never secured a congressional majority, its governments left a distinctive imprint through the creation of autonomous regulatory agencies in key policy areas, including telecommunications, energy, education, antitrust, and freedom of information. PAN administrations also spearheaded the federal government's war on drugs.

Partido de la Revolución Democrática: Formed through the alliance of the Mexican Communist Party and a major split from the PRI following the rise of the technocratic leadership, the often factionalized **PRD** occupied the center-left of the ideological spectrum (Bruhn 1997; Cantú 2019*a*; Özler 2009). Between 1997 and 2000, the party won seven gubernatorial elections, most notably in Mexico City, frequently by nominating defectors from state-level PRI organizations. Andrés Manuel López Obrador—better known by his initials, AMLO—was the PRD's presidential nominee in two unsuccessful campaigns before ultimately breaking away to found a new party under his personal leadership. Beginning in 2010, the PRD increasingly formed electoral alliances with the PAN, first in state elections and later at the federal level, a development that further distanced AMLO from the party. The PRD ultimately lost its legal registration in 2024.

Movimiento de Regeneración Nacional: AMLO's political gamble ultimately succeeded. His victorious third presidential campaign in 2018 consolidated much of the Mexican left behind **Morena**, while also attracting state-level political machines from both the PAN and

electoral process and the distributed time series.

the PRI. Morena won the presidency and secured majorities in Congress in the critical 2018 elections, subsequently expanding its control across most state governments. During the 2024 campaign, the party advanced a sustained critique of autonomous regulatory boards, arguing that these agencies—mostly shaped by the former major parties—had become entrenched obstacles to the governing majority. The supermajority obtained by Morena and its opportunistic allies in 2024 enabled a far-reaching constitutional transformation that dismantled many of the power-sharing arrangements associated with the previous three-party system, including a comprehensive overhaul of the judiciary. In this sense, the new dominant party has reunified political purpose, something unseen in Mexico since the era of the classic *PRIato*.

2.2 Opportunistic parties

Electoral institutions created incentives for the formation of new parties in pursuit of Mexico's generous public subsidies for political organizations. Yet formidable barriers to entry meant that success was generally limited to groups with preexisting organizational networks or access to undisclosed resources derived from state governments. In a field where many efforts failed, three parties achieved lasting relevance. The collapse of the competitive-era party system has further opened opportunities for their expansion, and all three have recently made important inroads into state-level government.

Movimiento Ciudadano: Originally the personal machine of a former governor of Veracruz, **MC**—formerly Convergencia por la Democracia—has expanded considerably over time. Positioning itself after 2018 as an alternative to the former major parties, MC consistently rejected invitations to join broad opposition coalitions. Although this opposition discoordination handed Morena numerous victories in municipalities, legislative districts, and even state elections, MC succeeded in winning the governorship of the populous state of Jalisco twice since 2018 and captured Nuevo León in 2021. Whether this strategy to become the sole credible opposition will succeed remains to be seen.

Green Party: A family-controlled political enterprise, the Partido Verde Ecologista de México (**PVEM**) stands out among Mexico's opportunistic parties. Its alliance votes may well have provided the PAN with its decisive margin in the 2000 presidential election.[7] The Greens subsequently became the PRI's reliable electoral partner in elections at virtually all levels during the 2003–18 period (Spoon and Pulido Gómez 2017). More recently, the party has

[7]The structure of the ballot prevents the breakdown of alliance votes by party. Estimating the PAN–PVEM alliance vote using the parties' relative vote shares in the congressional elections held three years earlier produces a Green Party contribution just below the margin of victory in the 2000 presidential election.

gravitated toward Morena's orbit. The PVEM won the governorship of Chiapas in 2012—the first gubernatorial victory by a non-major party—and later captured San Luis Potosí in 2021, thereby gaining access to additional organizational resources. Green Party legislators in Congress were also essential to sustaining Morena's governing coalition majority between 2021 and 2024 and its constitutional supermajority after 2024.

Workers' Party: Morena's other principal congressional ally is the Partido del Trabajo (**PT**). Originally emerging from radical urban movements of the 1970s in northern Mexico, it entered electoral coalitions with the PRD almost systematically throughout the competitive era. Its leadership aligned unequivocally with AMLO both before and after his break with the PRD. The PT has yet to win a governorship on its own.

3 Vote manipulation

Elections during the PRI era were neither fully free nor entirely fair. At the same time, they were not mere fabrications, but rather a heterogeneous combination of genuine electoral mobilization, daunting obstacles facing opposition parties, and at times blatant fraud (Cantú 2019*a*; Magaloni 2006; Molinar Horcasitas 1991). Democratization altered this equilibrium. The major parties created an autonomous federal electoral authority with broad and formidable powers, within which parties could monitor and check one another, thereby helping to level the playing field (Estévez, Magar and Rosas 2008). AMLO's refusal to concede defeat in the 2006 presidential race, for example, was never supported by compelling evidence of misconduct (Klesner 2007).

Fraud was never completely eliminated, as is likely the case in most democracies. Cantú's (2014) systematic study of "contiguous" polling stations in the 2010 local elections—where distrust remained greatest—detected relatively few irregularities. Moreover, because the major parties possessed roughly equal opportunities to engage in fraud when circumstances permitted, exceptional instances of manipulation tended to cancel out in the aggregate. By including elections from 1979 onward, this dataset provides additional leverage for comparing and evaluating municipal elections before and after the democratic reforms consolidated in 1997.

4 The data

The municipal elections dataset has been under construction for several years. The original core covering the 1970s and 1980s was assembled by Molinar Horcasitas (1991) from official vote returns produced by the Interior Ministry's Registro Nacional de Electores. This primary source was later systematized for northern Mexico by Magar (1994) and subsequently extended nationwide

by Varela (2004). Election results from the 1990s onward were compiled primarily from the state electoral authorities established around the turn of the century, which have generally reported vote returns since then. When official sources were unavailable or incomplete, secondary sources were consulted, most notably Voz y voto (1993) and CEDE-UAM-I (1991).

[Table 1 about here.]

The units of observation are municipalities observed across time. For each unit, the dataset reports the aggregate votes won by each party or electoral coalition in a given election, along with additional information on electoral history and unit identifiers. Table 1 summarizes data coverage by state. The resulting time-series cross-sectional matrix is unbalanced. One reason, reflected in the table column reporting the number of municipalities by state, is that many states created new municipalities during the period through territorial subdivision or secession, leaving these units without earlier electoral histories. Another source of imbalance stems from manipulation of state electoral calendars, which in some cases caused municipal elections to occur twice—or not at all—within a given three-year cycle (see section 8).[8]

State abbreviations are listed in the second column from the left and differ somewhat from those used by Mexican government agencies. My abbreviations are designed so that, when sorted in a standard spreadsheet, they preserve the Spanish alphabetization of the states, unlike the official abbreviations that do not.[9] For example, Guanajuato and Guerrero are abbreviated `gua` and `gue`, respectively, rather than the official `gto` and `gro`.

The time series begins in the 1979–1981 electoral cycle for most of the thirty-one states, and a few years earlier for a handful of others. (The Federal District, whose populous quasi-municipal jurisdictions are included in the dataset, is not formally a state and entered the series only in 2000.) This period was inaugurated by a major federal electoral reform that lowered legal barriers to electoral participation by parties and adopted a more proportional formula for converting votes into congressional seats (Molinar Horcasitas 1991:116). As a result, roughly half a dozen new parties entered the electoral arena and gradually expanded into municipal politics.

The data are available online, free of charge, from the webpage at:[10]

[8] File `ancillary/mun.yrs.csv` in the repository provides the complete list of municipalities for each electoral cycle with available municipal election returns. And file `ancillary/new-mun-parents-1989on.csv` identifies the parent municipalities from which the newly created units seceded.

[9] Table column # (state number), called field *edon* in the data, preserves Spanish alphabetization and is the prefix for official ID codes. Note that Spanish alphabetization places the letter Ch after the letter C, hence the state of Colima precedes Chiapas and Chihuahua.

[10] The datasets are actually archived and maintained in the `data/` subdirectory of my *Recent Mexican Election Vote Returns* repository that can be found at `https://github.com/emagar/elecRetrns`. Given the size and complexity of the repository—which also distributes electoral data for other state and federal elections at different levels of aggregation, along with primary sources, electoral laws, ancillary files, and related materials—the links provided in this webpage substantively facilitate locating, inspecting, and downloading the datasets discussed in this

https://emagar.github.io/municipio-repo/.

Files are stored in csv format (comma-separated values). This format is compatible with standard spreadsheet and statistical analysis software.[11] The appendix at the end of this note includes the codebook with formal definitions of all data fields (the codebook can also be downloaded from the webpage). Each row of the resulting data matrix corresponds to a unit at a specific time point—that is, a municipality in a given electoral year—while the columns correspond to the variables recorded for that unit-year observation. Among other information, the dataset includes the following fields:

- unit identifiers, including the municipality's name (field mun), state (edon), and official identification codes from the census bureau (inegi) and the federal electoral authority (ife); researchers wishing to merge socio-demographic information or vote returns from other elections into the dataset will rely on these codes to match observations across sources;
- the date of the election (fields date and yr);
- the vote tally (fields v01, v02, ...) obtained by each party or electoral coalition in the race (l01, l02, ...);
- the total effective vote (field efec), which is necessary to compute valid vote shares; efec equals the sum of all votes cast in the municipality that year (tot) excluding write-in votes (nr) and invalid ballots (nul);[12] and
- the total number of eligible registered voters in the municipal election (field lisnom, the *lista nominal*), which is required to calculate turnout rates.

[Figure 1 about here.]

Figure 1 provides a glimpse of the dataset for five municipalities in Baja California across three electoral cycles: yr=1998, 2001, and 2004. Municipal vote returns are stored in column pairs such as (v01,l01), (v02,l02), and so forth, corresponding to the first reported candidate, the second candidate, and so on. Within each pair, the l component identifies the party or coalition label, while the v component records the total votes won by the party or coalition. For example, in Ensenada's 1998 election, the PRI won a plurality of 31,995 votes (l02 = pri indicates that the

note. In addition, the webpage provides permalinks to the datasets as they existed at the time of publication, as well as links to updated versions incorporating subsequent electoral cycles as official returns become available.

[11] Text is encrypted using UTF-8 character encoding. Care has been taken to remove most Spanish special characters from text strings. Accented vowels (á, é, í, ó, ú, and ü) appear unaccented. The letter ñ, however, is retained to avoid ambiguity, and may appear as a garbled character on systems whose default encoding differs from UTF-8. See https://docs.python.org/3/howto/unicode.html for an introduction to character encoding.

[12] Write-in candidate votes (for *candidatos no registrados*) are considered void in Mexican electoral law.

PRI's vote total is stored in field `v02`), followed closely by the PAN with 30,660 votes (stored in field `v01`).

This votes–label pair-column structure accommodates four decades of heterogeneity in state-level party systems, compounded by the presence of short-lived electoral coalitions, while requiring a relatively small number of spreadsheet columns. The trade-off is that analyzing the performance of a single party across municipalities or across electoral cycles often requires additional data manipulation in order to align that party's vote totals into a common column across observations.[13]

5 Pre-election coalitions

Electoral coalitions constitute an important obstacle to analysis. Mexican electoral law distinguishes between two forms of pre-electoral alliances that parties may choose: joint candidacies and formal coalitions. In the former case, voters may cast ballots for any of the parties nominating the joint candidate—or for combinations of those parties—and these votes are subsequently aggregated to determine the candidate's total vote. In formal coalitions, by contrast, voters cast a single vote for the coalition as a whole, and results are reported without breakdown by member party.

Although these legal distinctions primarily affect the allocation of public party financing, they also substantially complicate voting studies. Researchers must decide whether to treat coalition votes as a pooled total for all member parties or to estimate each party's contribution separately, which in the case of formal coalitions requires auxiliary assumptions. To facilitate these choices, the repository distributes three separate municipal vote files:

- `data/aymu1970-on.coalAgg.csv` systematically aggregates votes cast for joint-candidacy coalitions, reporting the candidate's total vote as a single quantity;
- `data/aymu1970-on.coalSplit.csv` disaggregates the contribution of each coalition member party to the joint candidate's total vote. This procedure relies on the relative vote shares received by each party where the ballot structure provides such information; on coalition agreements between the parties where available and where the ballot design does not permit direct disaggregation; or, when neither alternative is feasible, on the relative vote shares obtained by the coalition partners the most recent time they competed separately in the municipality; and
- `data/aymu1970-on.csv` reports the raw vote totals exactly as they appear in the primary source—that is, aggregated vote totals for formal coalitions and party-level breakdowns

[13] A standalone R script extracts a simplified matrix, reporting each party's votes in a column that is named after it,

for joint candidacies.

The three files contain records for the exact same set of observations and report identical vote totals. They differ only in how coalition votes are recorded. Most users will choose between the `coalAgg` and the `coalSplit` versions. Researchers primarily interested in election winners and victory margins will generally prefer `coalAgg`, whereas those studying changes in party support over time will likely opt for `coalSplit`.

[Table 2 about here.]

Although coalitions were prohibited at the local level until the mid-1980s and only rarely authorized before the mid-1990s, they subsequently became a defining feature of Mexican elections, as shown in Table 2. Each row of the table reports the coalition profiles observed across municipal elections within a given triennium. With few exceptions resulting from changes in state electoral calendars,[14] triennial aggregates correspond to one regular election per municipality. A coalition profile is coded as 'None' when no coalition competed in the race; as 'major-minor' when one, two, or three major parties (PAN, PRI, PRD, or Morena) jointly nominated a municipal ticket with one or more minor parties; as 'Double major' when two major parties ran jointly (PAN+PRD, PAN+PRI, or PRI+PRD—Morena never did); and so forth.

Three distinct periods stand out. First, during triennia between 2000 and 2008, at least one major party—and increasingly two major parties—frequently allied with minor parties in an effort to gain an advantage in municipal contests. By the end of this period, four out of five municipal elections involved at least one major-minor arrangement. Second, 'Double-major' alliances became common between 2009 and 2014, particularly as the PAN and PRD formed anti-PRI coalitions in more than one-fifth of municipalities. During this period, races without coalitions became increasingly rare. Third, Morena's entry into the party system, especially after 2018, prompted repeated realignments among erstwhile rivals—the PAN, PRI, and PRD—which increasingly formed 'triple-major' coalitions to oppose the new dominant force. These broader alliances shrank the number of separate coalitions per municipality by expanding the scope of each coalition, as reflected in the rightmost column of the table, which reports the average number of coalitions per municipality during each triennium (shown in parentheses).

[Figure 2 about here.]

Computing the effective number of parties and candidates using the Laakso and Taagepera (1979) index—based on the `coalSplit` and `coalAgg` files, respectively—captures the increas-

for a single state-year's municipal races. The script is located in `code/extract-state-yr-mu-returns.r`.

[14] Subnational electoral calendars varied substantially up to 2015, but have since become increasingly aligned with

ing prevalence of coalitions particularly well. As shown longitudinally in Figure 2, a gap between the two measures emerged after major-party coalitions became normalized after 2009 and has continued to widen since then. The three distributed file structures therefore provide users with flexibility in handling coalitions according to their analytical needs. The repository also includes vote returns for federal and other state-level elections, for which the issues discussed in this section are likewise relevant. This note, however, focuses exclusively on municipal elections.[15]

6 Descriptive statistics

This section summarizes party vote shares across municipalities nationwide. Its purpose is to demonstrate that patterns of municipal party support in the distributed files conform to established interpretations of Mexico's unusual democratic transition (e.g. Cornelius 1996) and subsequent national political development (e.g. Cornelius and Weldon 2018). At the same time, the data also reveal patterns distinctive to municipal politics and illustrate several potential applications of the dataset.

[Figure 3 about here.]

Figure 3 provides a group portrait by plotting every municipal election since 1979 for which data are available, using the split-coalition file. Each small, color-coded circle quantifies a party's vote share in a single municipal election—137,813 observations in total, covering 30,633 non-missing municipal races. At the beginning of the series, the hegemonic party system of the 1960s and 1970s remained largely intact, with the PRI's red circles frequently concentrated at 100 percent of the vote, reflecting uncontested dominance (Segovia 1980). During the 1980s the center-right PAN (shown in blue), along with the emerging parties of the left (shown in gold),[16] achieved more than symbolic levels of support only in a very limited number of predominantly urban municipalities.

Opposition parties began gaining momentum after the economic crash of 1982, gradually chaneling social discontent into the electoral arena (Gómez Tagle 1990; Hiskey and Canache 2005;

the federal cycle (see section 8). Change is discernible in how municipal vote shares align vertically in the right of Figure 3, increasingly clustered over darker and more distinct columns that concur with federal elections.

[15]The repository also distributes returns to other federal and subnational races at different levels of aggregation. All files are in the `/data` folder: those whose name starts with `df` report federal deputy tallies, `se` are for senate races, `pr` for presidential elections, `go` for gubernatorial, and `dl` for state assemblies. The repository's `README` file provides details on the file-naming conventions.

[16]Several leftist incarnations are coded as PRD in the data: the Mexican Communist Party (PCM), PSUM, PMT, and PMS. The PRD was created in 1989, so this is a simplification of an overcrowded field. But PSUM used PCM's registration, then PMS used PSUM's, and PRD used PMS's. So other than the PMT, these are technically one and the same party outfit. See Molinar Horcasitas (1991).

Klesner 1993; Molinar Horcasitas 1991; Segovia 1983). The trend lines, which smooth party vote shares in the median municipality over time, clearly capture the steady erosion of PRI support and the rise of a dual opposition. Both processes, however, unfolded more slowly in municipal elections than national political developments during the second half of the 1980s might suggest. This apparent anomaly is largely explained by the enormous disparities in municipal population size. Ecological analyses of voting behavior consistently found that the strongest predictor of opposition voting was the proportion of the unit's population living in urban areas (Ames 1970; Lehr and Pedroza 1985; Magar 1994; Pacheco Méndez 1997; Walton and Sween 1973). Although relatively few in number, urban municipalities accounted for a substantial share of the total population. In a rapidly urbanizing society, this relationship foreshadowed the PRI's electoral vulnerability. At the same time, it highlighted a major obstacle for emerging parties, as the PRI remained a formidable competitor in smaller, rural, low-turnout municipal enclaves. Until late in the series, only the PRI possessed the organizational capacity to mobilize voters in these localities. The median municipality remained firmly embedded within such rural enclaves until the mid-1990s.

[Figure 4 about here.]

Figure 4 approaches this lag from a somewhat different angle by focusing on winners in municipal races. In Panel A, each horizontal bar reports the proportion of municipalities won by each party during a triennial electoral cycle, using the coalition aggregates file. For visual simplicity, victories by coalition tickets are assigned to the major party involved; when two or three major parties competed jointly, the victory is assigned arbitrarily to the largest of them within the corresponding state-cycle. The PRI won nearly all municipal elections in the first three triennia covered by the series. Its subsequent decline remained barely noticeable as late as 1993, after which electoral losses accelerated but were interrupted by periods of apparent stability: roughly nine out of ten municipal victories between 1988 and 1993, three out of four between 1994 and 1999, and approximately half between 2000 and 2014. The party's final collapse came with Morena's rise to dominance. In the final electoral cycle reported, the PRI won only one in ten municipalities only.

Panel B weights municipalities by their share of all registered voters, thereby reflecting the proportion of the national electorate governed by each party in a given cycle. Up to 2008, the PAN's bars are notably larger in panel B than in A, illustrating the party's distinctive urban bias.

The simultaneous rise of a dual opposition in Figure 3 created a coordination problem for anti-PRI voters, which helped prolong the PRI's rule even after the erosion of its hegemonic status (Garrido de Sierra 2014; Magaloni 2006).[17] Figure 5 reports the distribution of the three-party vote among the major parties—that is, after subtracting votes cast for candidates outside the PAN-

[17]The PAN and left's parallel paths are suggestive of what Cox (1997) terms 'non-Duvergerian' equilibria: a near tie between challengers that often left the PRI invulnerable in office despite erosion of its support.

PRI-PRD trio. Municipalities won uncontested by the PRI cluster around the upper vertex of the triangle, while movements away from that point measure gradual declines in PRI support in favor of the PAN and/or the PRD. The ternary plot reproduces a pattern previously identified in federal elections (Márquez 2014): between 1989 (the PRD's debut year) and 2014 (the year before Morena's entry), most observations lie on or very near the edges of the triangle. Although some municipalities lie within the interior, they are comparatively uncommon. This pattern indicates predominantly local two-party competition. In other words, opposition support was regionally concentrated: the PRI typically faced a serious challenge from either the PAN or the PRD, but rarely from both simultaneously. The PRI's persistence in municipal elections therefore reflected not merely failures of opposition coordination, but also genuine organizational and electoral strength.

[Figure 5 about here.]

The final stage depicted in the data corresponds to the collapse of the party system that structured Mexico's democratic transition (Moreno 2009), and to the rise of AMLO's Morena. AMLO overcame the chronic factionalism of the Mexican left (Bruhn 1997) by launching his new party structured around his personal leadership. The strategy proved successful. Left-wing elite discoordination allowed rival parties to secure unexpected victories in Morena's inaugural 2015 elections. Three years later, however, AMLO's third presidential campaign became a focal point that attracted not just left-wing voters but also independents and defectors from both the PRI and the PAN. Morena's landslide victory in 2018, which gave the party unified control of the federal government and most state governments, prompted the former major parties to form broad triple-major coalitions in subsequent elections. These desperate efforts achieved little success. Although Morena's rise appears with some lag in Figure 3—because the party first consolidated support in the largest municipalities before expanding into smaller ones—its electoral strength ultimately succeeded in realigning local elites away from the PRI. By the 2024 electoral cycle, the PRI's population-weighted bar in Figure 4 had finally fallen below its already diminished share of municipal victories.

7 Elected officers and reelection

Another component of the dataset, distributed in the file

`data/aymu1989-on.incumbents.csv`,

focuses on elected officeholders. Coverage begins only in 1989, as earlier information is largely missing. Table 3 shows that municipal government remained an overwhelming male domain until

2015. Nevertheless, the proportion of female municipal executives increased steadily throughout the period before leveling off towards the end of the series.

In 2015, a parity law entered into force, constitutionally requiring parties nationwide to nominate equal numbers of female and male candidates across elected offices (Piscopo 2016). The reform more than doubled the number of women elected to municipal office. Even so, women remain underrepresented relative to full parity, as female candidates continue to lose to male candidates more frequently than the reverse. Whether these unequal success rates reflect the difficulty of rapidly recruiting experienced female candidates, the tendency of parties to nominate women in less competitive races, anti-female bias among voters, or other factors remains an important subject for future research.

[Table 3 about here.]

[Figure 6 about here.]

The incumbents dataset also makes it possible to study patterns of consecutive reelection following its adoption (López-Videla Mostajo 2021; Lucardi and Rosas 2016; Motolinia 2021). Figure 6 presents party reelection rates during the 2018–2023 period conditional on the status of the outgoing municipal president: incumbents who sought reelection appear in shades of green, incumbents barred by term limits in shades of red, and open-seat races in shades of blue. Several noteworthy patterns emerge:

- The consistency of the darker green bars, representing incumbents who successfully won reelection, is striking: approximately 21 percent overall, varying only $\pm$ 3 percentage points across parties other than the PRD—which was on its way out after the reform. At first glance, a one-in-five reelection rate may not appear particularly high. However, the combined total of both green-shaded bars captures officeholders displaying static ambition regardless of electoral success: roughly 38 percent overall, with greater variation.

- The red-shaded bars represent executive officeholders who had already secured reelection in the 2018 cycle and were therefore ineligible to seek a third consecutive term. Because these officials had already demonstrated static ambition, they should be grouped conceptually with the green categories when evaluating the attractiveness of municipal reelection. By the second post-reform electoral cycle, approximately three out of five mayors attempted to remain in office. This provides a more meaningful indicator of reelection incentives. Particularly striking is the 58 percent rate among Morena incumbents, given that the party's national leadership later supported abolishing reelection beginning in 2030.

- The blue-shaded category reports incumbents who retired from office, leaving an average of 38 percent of races as open seats. Unfortunately, the dataset does not distinguish whether these withdrawals reflected voluntary retirement or denial of renomination by the incumbent's party. This limitation represents an important opportunity for future extensions of the dataset.

8 The electoral calendar

The final component of the dataset, distributed in the file

`data/aymu1989-on.concurrence.csv`,

relates the timing of each municipal election to the broader electoral calendar. Four dummy variables indicate whether a given municipal election concurred with a gubernatorial, state assembly, presidential, or congressional election.[18] The dataset therefore makes it possible to study coattail effects and other electoral spillovers across races (e.g., Ames 1994; Magar 2012). It also enables systematic analysis of changes in state electoral timing, an institutional feature that merits closer scrutiny. Figure 7 shows how the diverse state calendars have gradually become more aligned with the federal calendar over time.

[Figure 7 about here.]

9 Conclusion

The publicly distributed datasets cover roughly half a century of recent Mexican municipal electoral history. The repository includes vote returns for 35,528 non-missing municipal elections across the states beginning in the 1979–81 electoral cycle. The units of observation in the time-series cross-sectional data are municipality–election year observations, providing a basis for describing and analyzing patterns of sub-state partisan support. The data also include information on the electoral calendar for 25,456 municipal elections relative to other potentially concurrent contests since the 1990s, as well as the names of 24,088 elected municipal presidents during the same period.

The breadth of systematized information contained in these datasets offers extensive opportunities for empirical analysis. This research note has illustrated how the observed patterns correspond to several well-established findings in the literature on Mexican elections, while also pointing toward numerous promising avenues for future research.

[18] See Magar (2017) for detail. The distributed electoral calendar dummies derive from this repository.

10 Declaration on the use of AI

Data was fully retrieved, prepared, and systematized by humans (the author and research assistants). Manuscript drafts up to the version that was submitted to this journal were fully written by the author, without reliance on AI tools. The author maintains full responsibility for the final content.

11 Appendix: codebook for variables in the datasets

11.1 Variables grouped by type

11.1.1 Unit identification

emm = unit's unique identifying code. It concatenates the state's **edo** abbreviation (then a hyphen), two sequential digits for the electoral cycle (then a period) and the **inegi** identifier. When a special election took place for which I have the returns, the voided election has an 'a' inserted after the electoral cycle. Using **emm** as sort criterion returns a state-time-unit ordering.

inegi, ife = municipal identifier codes used by the INEGI and the IFE/INE, respectively.

mun = municipality name.

edon = state number (1–32).

edo = state abbreviation (may differ from commonly used abbreviations, so that sorting them alphabetically preserves the order set by edon, e.g. San Luis Potosí is 'san' instead of the usual 'slp').

11.1.2 Temporal identification

date = date of the election, stored in an 8-digit numeric value in yyyymmdd format.

yr, mo, dy = year, month, day of the election.

dextra = dummy equal 1 for special elections (*elección extraordinaria*), 0 otherwise.

11.1.3 Voting

mg = winner's margin = winner's vote share minus runner-up's vote share.

win = winner's party or coalition.

v01, v02, ... = raw vote for candidates 1, 2, etc. In the coalition-aggregated dataset only, raw vote variables are sorted in decreasing order: v01 reports the votes won by the most-voted candidate, v02 the votes won by the runner-up, and so forth.

l01, l02, ... = string label of candidate 1's, candidate 2's, etc., party or coalition.

nr = votes for write-in candidates (*candidatos no registrados*, void in Mexican election law).

nulos = invalid ballots (*votos nulos*).

efec = effective vote total, equal to the sum of raw votes minus votes for write-in candidates minus invalid ballots. This is the denominator to compute vote shares.

tot = total raw votes.

lisnom = unit's total eligible voters (*lista nominal*).

11.1.4 Candidates and incumbent municipal presidents

ncand = number of candidates running.

ncoal = number of candidates running on multi-party pre-electoral coalitions.

incumbent, runnerup = winning and runner-up candidates' names.

race.after = incumbent's status in the next consecutive race, reporting what occurred at the end of the current term. It takes one of the following categories:

- 'Reran-beaten' = the incumbent re-ran and lost;
- 'Reelected' = the incumbent re-ran and won;
- 'Out' = the incumbent withdrew or was not renominated in the next cycle;
- 'Term-limited' = incumbent ineligible for reelection due to a term limit;
- 'Dead' = the incumbent died in office;
- 'Uyc' = municipality ceased electing authorities by popular vote in the next cycle, appointing offices according to community rules (*usos y costumbres*);
- A year numeral = incumbent's status still to be determined (and the year of the race that will determine it).

In categories other than the first two above, suffix '-p-lost' or '-p-won' indicate, respectively, that the party lost the subsequent race (or, in case of incumbents elected by a multi-party coalition, that none of them won or was part of the winning coalition) or that the party won the subsequent race (or, in case of incumbents elected by a multi-party coalition, that one of them won or was part of the winning coalition).

dmujer = dummy equal 1 if incumbent is a woman, 0 otherwise.

part = winner's party or coalition.

part2nd = runner-up party or coalition.

11.1.5 Concurrence with other races

dconcpres = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a presidential election, 0 otherwise.

dconcdipf = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a congressional election, 0 otherwise.

dconcgob = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a gubernatorial election, 0 otherwise.

dconcdipl = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a state assembly election, 0 otherwise.

11.1.6 Ancillary information

status = string variable for housekeeping. It takes one of the following categories:

- 'ok' = returns have been revised; no issues reported;
- 'new' = new municipality electing its authorities for the first time;
- 'missing' = data unavailable;
- 'appointed' = state assembly appointed a Concejo Municipal (municipal council) due to post-election civil strife or other circumstances preventing an election from being held;
- 'cancelled' = voided election;
- 'extra' = special election;
- 'from-uyc' = municipality re-instituted periodic elections after appointing municipal officers through *usos y costumbres* norms.

fuente = source of the data.

notas = warnings, issues, and possibly informative annotations.

ord = counter, used for housekeeping.

drepe, drepg, dlegacy, who = experimental variables with development in progress but insufficient for use in analysis.

11.2 Variables sorted alphabetically

date = date of the election, stored in an 8-digit numeric value in yyyymmdd format.

dconcdipf = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a congressional election, 0 otherwise.

dconcdipl = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a state assembly election, 0 otherwise.

dconcgob = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a gubernatorial election, 0 otherwise.

dconcpres = dummy equal 1 if the municipal election concurred with a presidential election, 0 otherwise.

ddied = experimental variable with development in progress but insufficient for use in analysis.

dextra = dummy equal 1 for special elections (elección extraordinaria), 0 otherwise.

dlegacy = experimental variable with development in progress but insufficient for use in analysis.

dmujer = dummy equal 1 if incumbent is a woman, 0 otherwise.

drepe = experimental variable with development in progress but insufficient for use in analysis.

drepg = experimental variable with development in progress but insufficient for use in analysis.

dy = day of the election.

edo = state abbreviation (may differ from commonly used abbreviations, so that sorting them alphabetically preserves the order set by edon, e.g. San Luis Potosí is 'san' instead of the usual 'slp').

edon = state number (1–32).

efec = effective vote total, equal to the sum of raw votes minus votes for write-in candidates minus invalid ballots. This is the denominator to compute vote shares.

emm = unit's unique identifying code. It concatenates the state's **edo** abbreviation (then a hyphen), two sequential digits for the electoral cycle (then a period) and the **inegi** identifier. When a special election took place for which I have the returns, the voided election has an 'a' inserted after the electoral cycle. Using **emm** as sort criterion returns a state-time-unit ordering.

fuente = source of the data.

ife = municipal identifier codes used by the IFE/INE.

incumbent = winning candidates' names.

inegi = municipal identifier codes used by the INEGI.

l01, l02, ... = string label of candidate 1's, candidate 2's, etc., party or coalition.

lisnom = unit's total eligible voters (lista nominal).

mg = winner's margin = winner's vote share minus runner-up's vote share.

mo = month of the election.

mun = municipality name.

ncand = number of candidates running.

ncoal = number of candidates running on multi-party pre-electoral coalitions.

notas = warnings, issues, and informative annotations.

nr = votes for write-in candidates (candidatos no registrados, void in Mexican election law).

nulos = invalid ballots (votos nulos).

ord = counter used for housekeeping.

part = incumbent party or coalition.

part2nd = runner-up party or coalition.

race.after = incumbent's status in the next consecutive race, reporting what occurred at the end of the current term. It takes one of the following categories:

- 'Reran-beaten' = the incumbent re-ran and lost;
- 'Reelected' = the incumbent re-ran and won;
- 'Out' = the incumbent withdrew or was not renominated in the next cycle;
- 'Term-limited' = incumbent ineligible for reelection due to a term limit;
- 'Dead' = the incumbent died in office;
- 'Uyc' = municipality ceased electing authorities by popular vote in the next cycle, appointing offices according to community rules (*usos y costumbres*);
- A year numeral = incumbent's status still to be determined (and the year of the race that will determine it).

In categories other than the first two above, suffix '-p-lost' or '-p-won' indicate, respectively, that the party lost the subsequent race (or, in case of incumbents elected by a multi-party coalition, that none of them won or was part of the winning coalition) or that the party won the subsequent race (or, in case of incumbents elected by a multi-party coalition, that one of them won or was part of the winning coalition).

runnerup = runner-up candidates' names.

status = string variable for housekeeping. It takes one of the following categories:

- 'ok' = returns have been revised; no issues reported;
- 'new' = new municipality electing its authorities for the first time;
- 'missing' = data unavailable;
- 'appointed' = state assembly appointed a Concejo Municipal (municipal council) due to post-election civil strife or other circumstances preventing an election from being held;
- 'cancelled' = voided election;
- 'extra' = special election;
- 'from-uyc' = municipality re-instituted periodic elections after appointing municipal officers through *usos y costumbres* norms.

tot = total raw votes.

v01, v02, ... = raw vote for candidates 1, 2, etc. In the coalition-aggregated dataset only, raw vote variables are sorted in decreasing order: v01 reports the votes won by the most-voted candidate, v02 the votes won by the runner-up, and so forth.

who = experimental variable with development in progress but insufficient for use in analysis.

win = winner's party or coalition.

yr = year of the election.

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C	D	E	F	G	J	K	L	M	N	O
yr	inegi	ife	mun	edon	v01	l01	v02	l02	v03	l03
1998	2001	2001	ENSENADA	2	30660	pan	31951	pri	12441	prd
1998	2002	2002	MEXICALI	2	89354	pan	81676	pri	13899	prd
1998	2003	2003	TECATE	2	4590	pan	9353	pri	4983	prd
1998	2004	2004	TIJUANA	2	116244	pan	98669	pri	25065	prd
1998	2005	2005	PLAYAS DE ROSARITO	2	6055	pan	5058	pri	1367	prd
2001	2001	2001	ENSENADA	2	32262	pan-pvem	31582	pri	12048	prd
2001	2002	2002	MEXICALI	2	95674	pan-pvem	67434	pri	11615	prd
2001	2003	2003	TECATE	2	7796	pan-pvem	7862	pri	2066	prd
2001	2004	2004	TIJUANA	2	108921	pan-pvem	87433	pri	13928	prd
2001	2005	2005	PLAYAS DE ROSARITO	2	6324	pan-pvem	3141	pri	348	prd
2004	2001	2001	ENSENADA	2	32604	pan	30839	pri-pvem-pt-pebc	13537	prd
2004	2002	2002	MEXICALI	2	63855	pan	63892	pri-pvem-pt-pebc	9021	prd
2004	2003	2003	TECATE	2	9216	pan	10331	pri-pvem-pt-pebc	1112	prd
2004	2004	2004	TIJUANA	2	134428	pan	139230	pri-pvem-pt-pebc	9887	prd
2004	2005	2005	PLAYAS DE ROSARITO	2	7056	pan	4170	pri-pvem-pt-pebc	4539	prd

Figure 1: Screenshot with a sample of the data organization

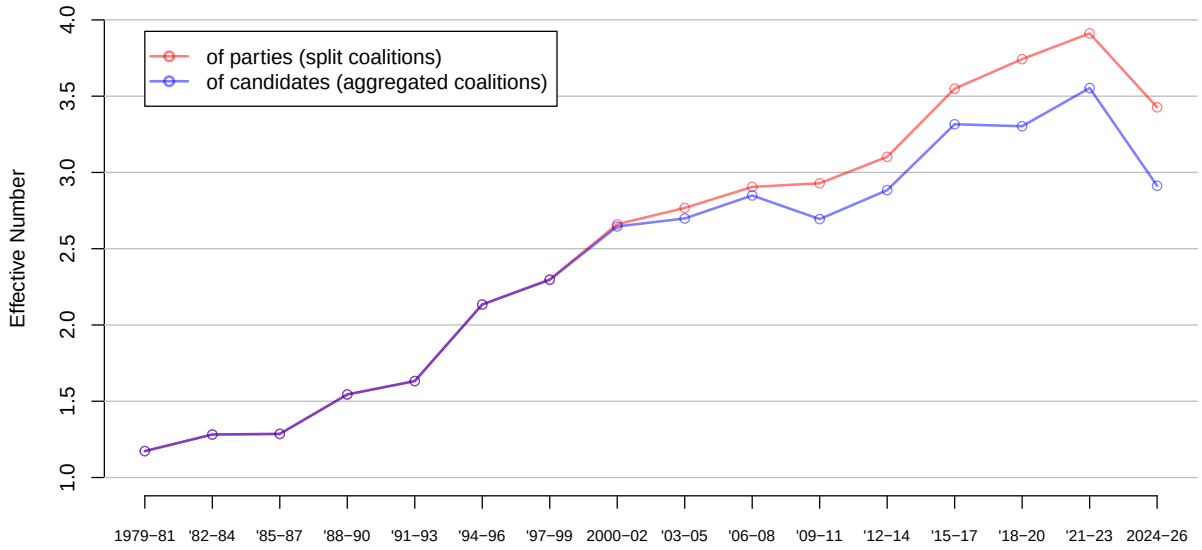


Figure 2: Municipal party system fragmentation by federal election cycle. Circles report the mean effective number of parties across municipal elections in the cycle.

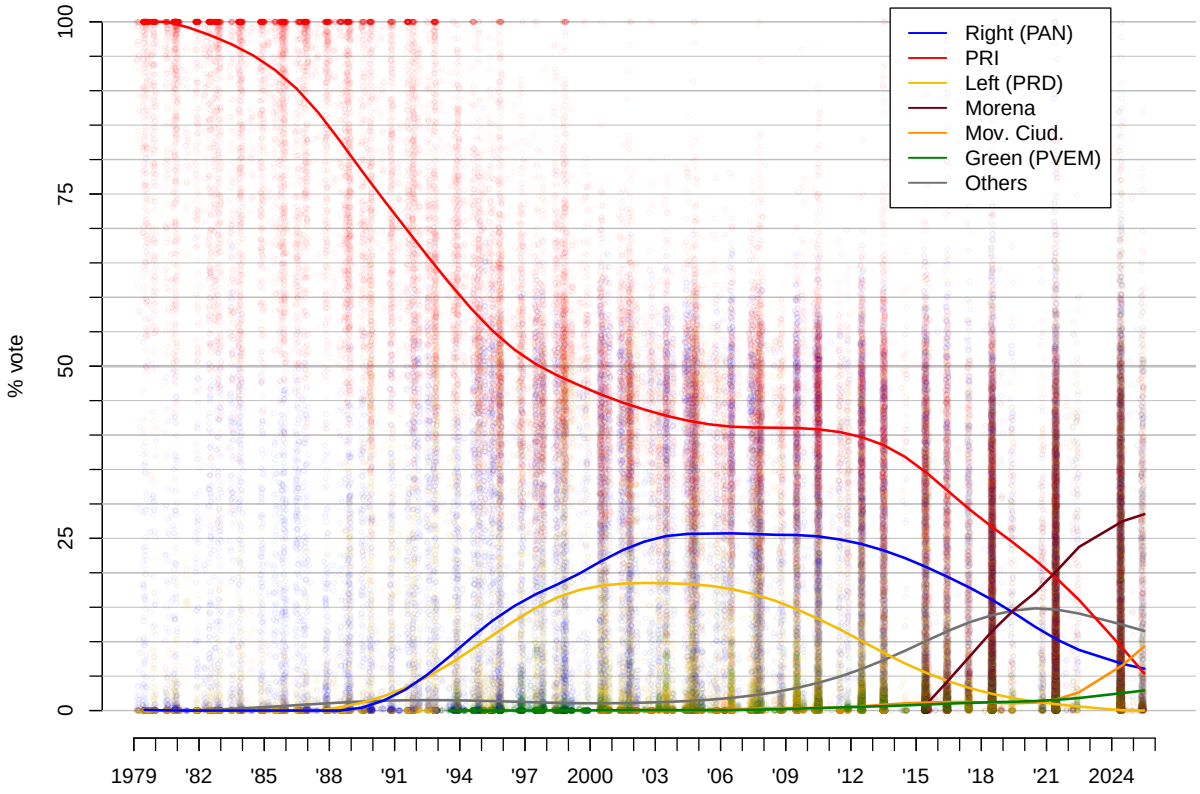


Figure 3: The electoral evolution of parties in municipal races 1979–2025. Color-coded circles report a given party's vote percentage in a municipal election (slightly x-jittered for visibility). Curves show the vote share that won by each party in the median municipality over time (the trend is smoothed for clarity).

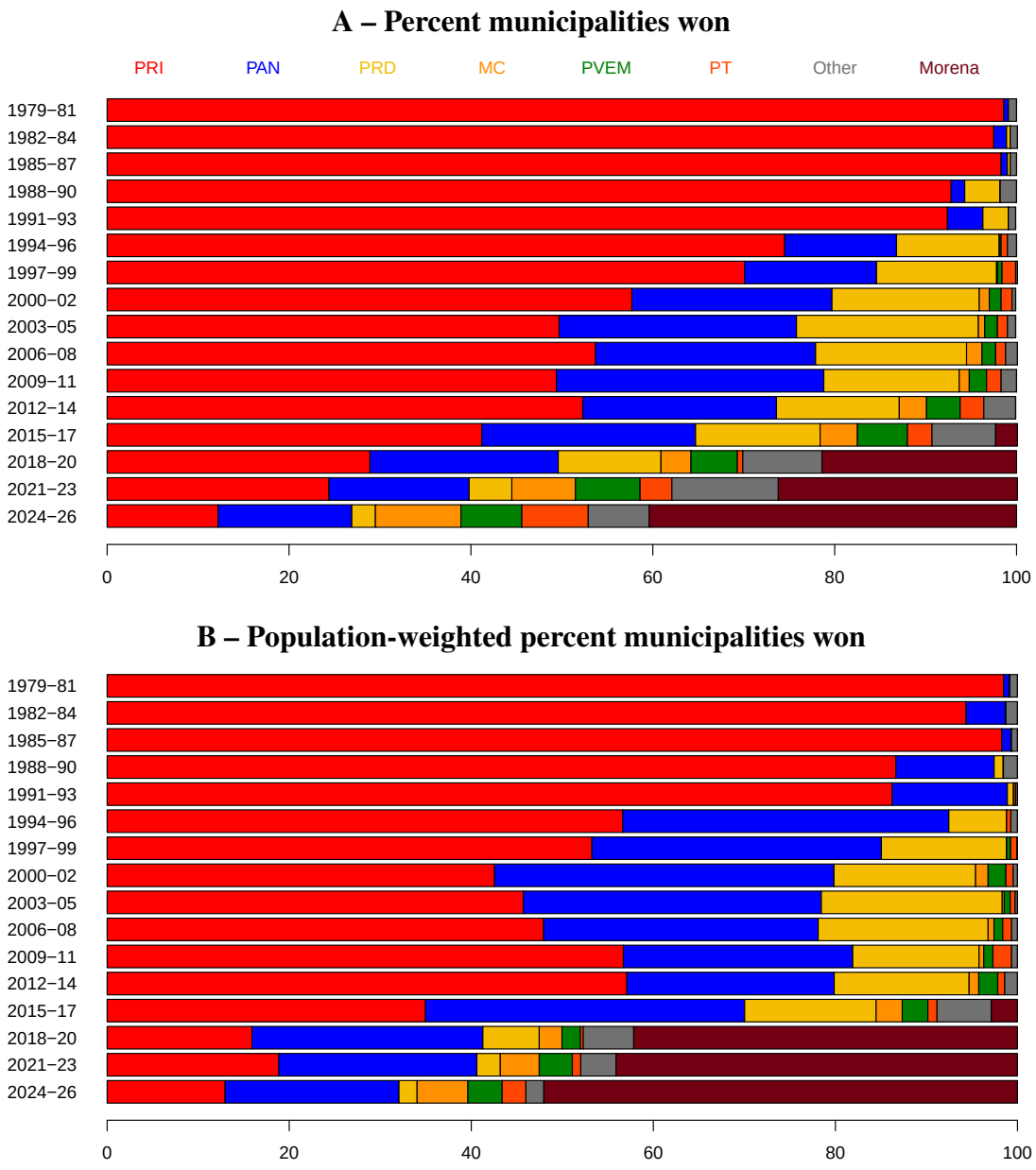


Figure 4: Winners by triennial federal electoral cycle. Relative frequencies in panel B are weighted by the municipality's size. See text on how coalition victories were handled.

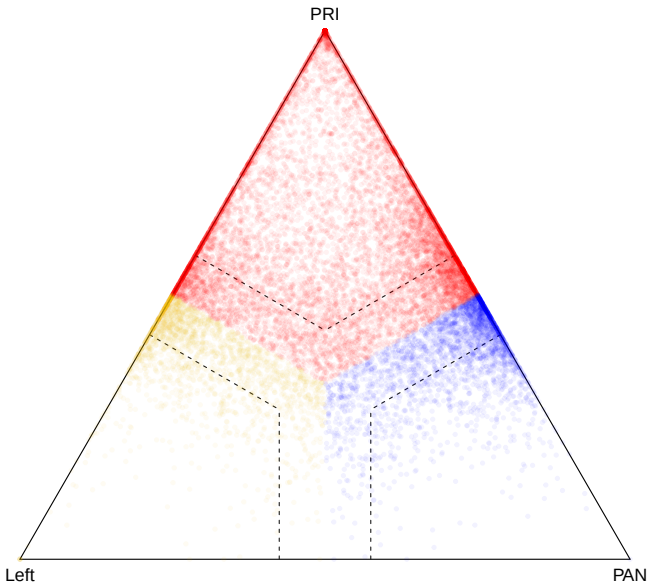


Figure 5: Predominantly bipartisan rivalries before Morena. The ternary plot reports the share of the three-party vote that major parties won in municipal elections in the 1989–2014 period (excluding the Federal District). Points inside the dotted area are marginal municipalities, where the difference between the top-two parties was 10 percentage points or less.

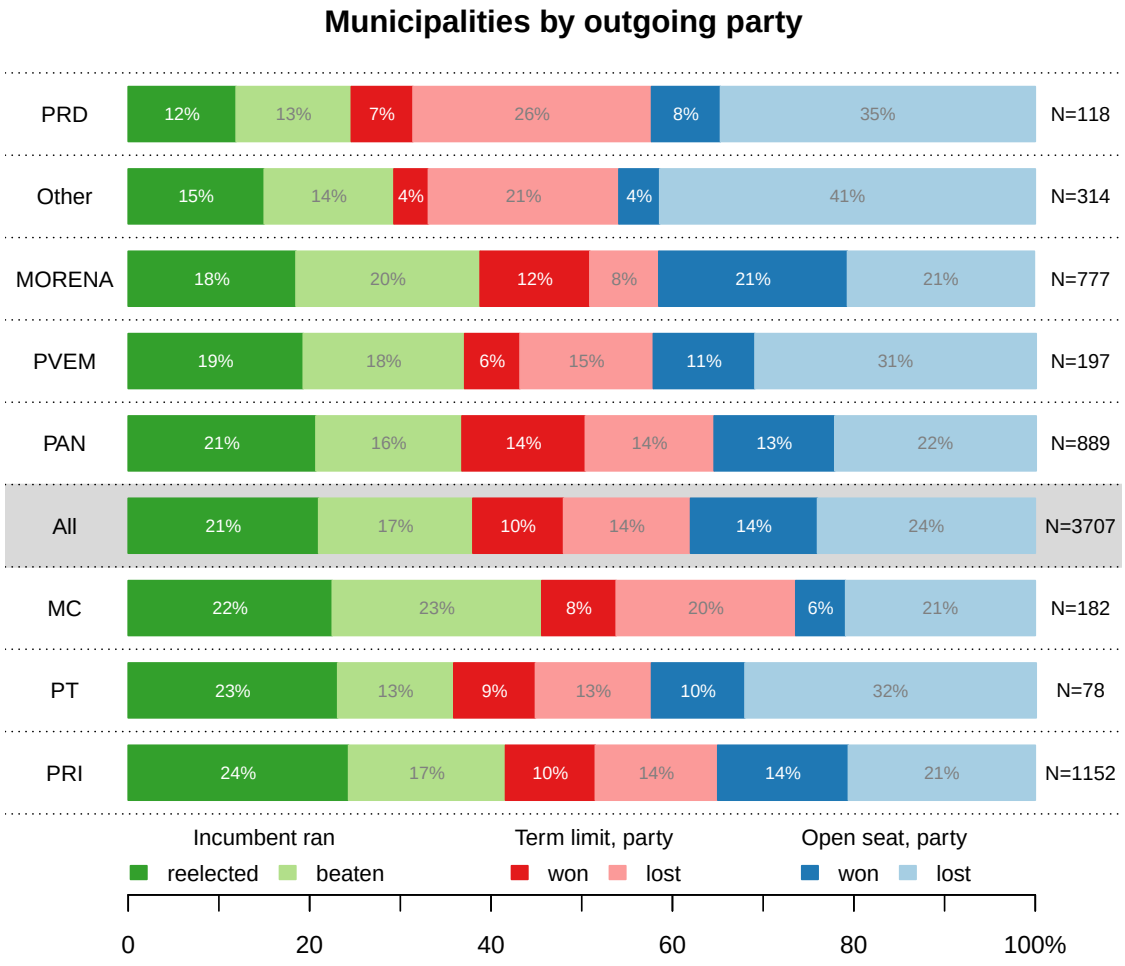


Figure 6: Governing-party reelection since 2018, by status of the incumbent municipal president. The 2024–26 cycle is dropped because reelection rates remain to be determined. Earlier cycles are dropped because they predate the adoption of municipal consecutive reelection.

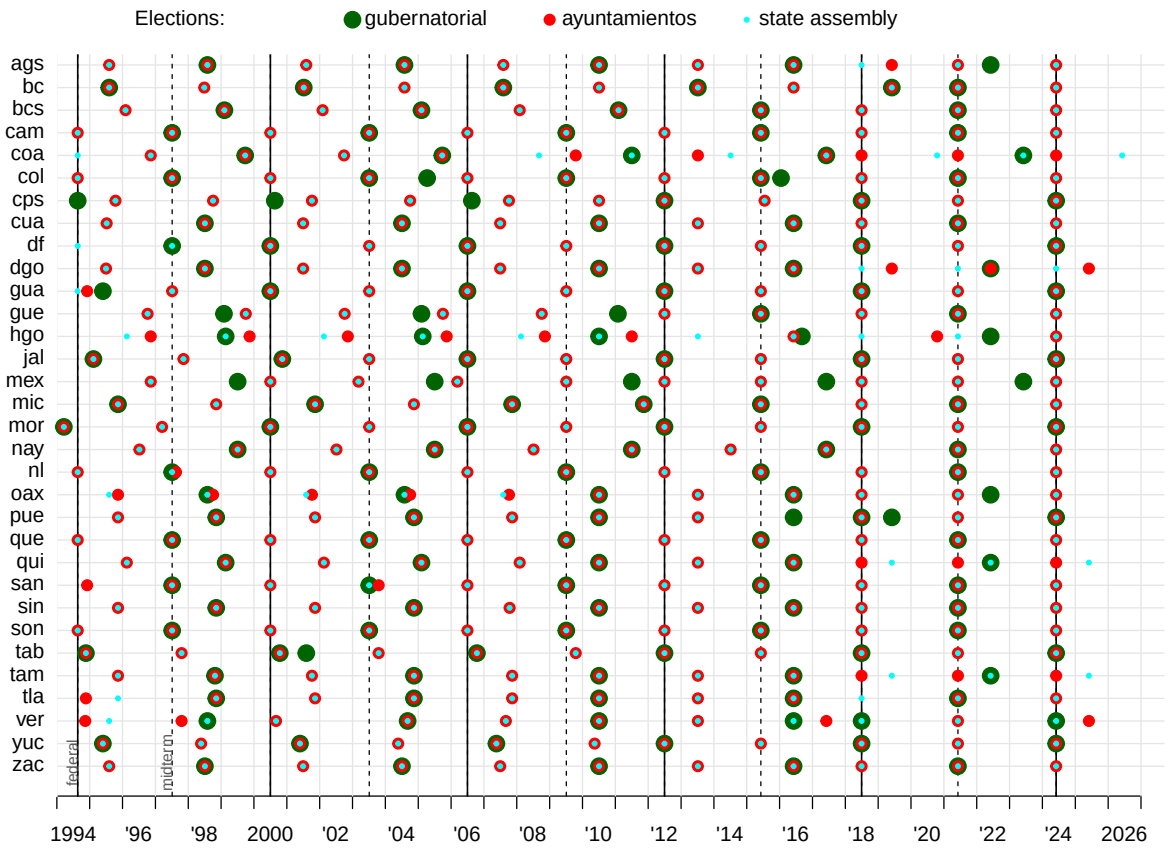


Figure 7: Gradual alignment of state and federal electoral calendars 1994–2026. The X-axis measures time, with ticks corresponding to January 1 of each year. Vertical black lines indicate the dates of federal races, solid lines for general elections, dotted lines for midterm elections. Circumferences indicate when state elections took place, colored as indicated in the top legend.

#	Abbrev.	State	N municipalities	Years included
1	ags	Aguascalientes	9–11	1977–2024
2	bc	Baja California	4–7	1971–2024
3	bcs	Baja California Sur	3–5	1974–2024
4	cam	Campeche	8–13	1979–2024
5	coa	Coahuila	38	1978–2024
6	col	Colima	10	1976–2024
7	cps	Chiapas†	110–126	1976–2024
8	cua	Chihuahua	67	1974–2024
9	df	Distrito Federal/Mexico City‡	16	1997–2024
10	dgo	Durango	38–39	1971–2025
11	gua	Guanajuato	46	1979–2024
12	gue	Guerrero†	75–85	1977–2024
13	hgo	Hidalgo	84	1981–2024
14	jal	Jalisco	124–125	1976–2024
15	mex	México	121–125	1978–2024
16	mic	Michoacán†	112–113	1977–2024
17	mor	Morelos†	33–36	1976–2024
18	nay	Nayarit	19–20	1972–2024
19	nl	Nuevo León	51	1973–2024
20	oax	Oaxaca†	570	1977–2024
21	pue	Puebla	217	1980–2024
22	que	Querétaro	18	1973–2024
23	qui	Quintana Roo	7–11	1978–2024
24	san	San Luis Potosí	56–58	1970–2024
25	sin	Sinaloa	17–20	1971–2024
26	son	Sonora	69–72	1976–2024
27	tab	Tabasco	17	1976–2024
28	tam	Tamaulipas	43	1971–2024
29	tla	Tlaxcala	44–60	1979–2024
30	ver	Veracruz	203–212	1976–2025
31	yuc	Yucatán	106	1981–2024
32	zac	Zacatecas	56–58	1970–2024
		Municipalities nationwide by election cycle	2375–2477	1970–2025

Table 1: Coverage of the municipal election returns dataset. † Reforms during the period removed *usos y costumbres* municipalities from the system of periodic elections (see section 1.6): one municipality in Chiapas since 2021, one in Guerrero since 2018 and another since 2024, one in Michoacán since 2011, three in Morelos since 2021, and between 412 and 418 in Oaxaca since 1995. ‡ Administrative jurisdictions in the Federal District became elected offices since 2000, see section 1.2.

	Coalition profile relative frequency (%)										
	None	Major-minor			Double-major			Triple-major		Total	(Mean
Cycle		one	two	three	only	and one maj.-min.	and two maj.-min.	only	and one maj.-min.		coali-tions)
1979–81	100	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	100	(0.00)
1982–84	100	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	100	(0.00)
1985–87	100	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	100	(0.00)
1988–90	94	6	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	100	(0.06)
1991–93	99	1	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	100	(0.01)
1994–96	100	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	100	(0.01)
1997–99	97	2	—	—	2	—	—	—	—	100	(0.04)
2000–02	77	17	2	—	4	—	—	—	—	100	(0.29)
2003–05	53	30	12	—	2	3	—	—	—	100	(0.65)
2006–08	20	48	30	1	—	1	—	—	—	100	(1.19)
2009–11	11	32	15	10	8	24	—	—	—	100	(1.54)
2012–14	9	51	12	4	4	22	—	—	—	100	(1.39)
2015–17	25	36	11	1	6	22	—	—	—	100	(1.16)
2018–20	6	17	15	7	7	35	13	—	—	100	(1.86)
2021–23	27	19	—	—	13	10	—	18	14	100	(1.05)
2024–26	17	20	2	—	6	13	1	17	25	100	(1.30)

Table 2: Coalitional profile of municipal races by federal election cycle. Cells report the percentage of municipalities in the cycle, and the cycle's mean number of coalitions per race in parentheses. Quantities consider only coalitions in which at least one partner was a major party (PAN, PRI, PRD, or Morena), ignoring coalitions among minor parties only, which were also quite frequent. Rounded percentages may not add to 100.

Cycle	% female mayors	
1988–90†	2	
1991–93	4	
1994–96	4	
1997–99	4	
2000–02	5	
2003–05	5	
2006–08	6	
2009–11	8	
2012–14	11	
2015–17	21	*Gender parity slates adopted*
2018–20	28	
2021–23	27	
2024–26	28	

Table 3: Municipal glass ceilings dented. The dashed line separates cycles before and after the nomination of 50 percent women became compulsory for all parties. † The 1988 election year from the first cycle is missing.